MODULE-6 · MASTERCLASS DOSSIER

6.3 The Release Calendar

Lesson masterclass · implementation drills · war-room directive

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Plan a 12-week, three-release cadence.
- Align releases to market-attention windows by quarter.
- Reserve Q4 for the annual audit and strategy season.

★ **INSIDER RADIO TIP**

Timing is market-attention windows: Q1 post-holiday open, Q2 spring/summer booking, Q3 fall breakout, Q4 closed. Never release into Q4 as an unknown — use it for the annual audit.

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6.3 The Release Calendar That Dominates Quarters

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THE ONE-LINE TRUTH: A release is not an isolated event — it is a 12-week military operation. The artists who own radio run an annual calendar with three armed campaigns a year, backwards-engineered from impact dates.

MASTERCLASS DIRECTIVE & STRATEGIC BLUEPRINT

Strategic Foundation & Operational Reality

The most destructive behavior in the independent music ecosystem is the sporadic, impulsive release cycle. An artist records a single, finishes the master on a Wednesday, uploads it to a digital distributor on Friday, posts on social media on Monday, and by week two has exhausted their promotional energy. They spend the next four months in creative hibernation, wondering why their career lacks commercial continuity.

Dominion operators treat the calendar as an **Enterprise Production System**.

You do not “drop singles.” You execute **Quarterly Operational Campaigns**. A sustainable, highly profitable independent music enterprise operates on a strict cadence of **three major campaigns per year**, with each campaign structured as a 12-week continuous execution timeline backwards-engineered from an official **Radio Impact Date**.

Why Three Releases Per Year Beats Monthly Chaos

Digital distribution “gurus” advocate releasing a new single every 30 days to game Spotify recommendation algorithms. For a serious broadcast campaign, this strategy is catastrophic:

- Radio programming departments operate on multi-week evaluation cycles. It takes 14 to 21 days just for a programmer to listen, evaluate, and assign a track to an add meeting.
- If you release a new track every 4 weeks, you abandon your first single just as radio rotation is beginning to build.
- You burn out your station allies with constant, frantic, low-quality submissions.

Three disciplined, fully armed 12-week campaigns per year give each single sufficient runway to achieve full regional saturation, rotation upgrades, tour sync, and revenue harvest.

The 12-Week Master Operational Timeline

- **Weeks 1 – 2 (The Proof & Asset Build):** Final master delivered (-14 LUFS, −1.0 dBTP), FCC clean edit bounced, 90-second audio weapon and 30-second sweeper created, ID3 metadata stamped, proof stack refreshed.
- **Weeks 3 – 4 (Target Architecture Lockdown):** Hometown Heat Map audited, 60 candidates scored via 100-Point Format Scorecard, 20-Station War Room Cockpit finalized and verified.
- **Weeks 5 – 6 (Weapon Staging & Gate Clearance):** One-Page Command Deck EPK updated, 20 customized 3-layer subject lines pre-drafted, all 7 Load Sequence gates verified green.
- **Weeks 7 – 8 (The Pre-Roll Launch):** Tour dates confirmed and locked in target station markets, venue interview windows scheduled, station ticket giveaways structured.
- **Week 9 (Wave 1 Dispatch & Impact Week):** Wave 1 dispatches Tuesday 9:30 AM local time. Four-hour monitoring window active. Real-time Spinitron tracking initiated.
- **Week 10 (Wave 2 & Touch 2 Escalation):** Wave 2 dispatches Thursday 9:30 AM local time. Wave 1 receives Touch 2 Asset Drop (30-second hook cut + tour dates).
- **Week 11 (Touch 3 & Cascade Loops):** Touch 3 Dignified Exit dispatched to unresponsive targets. First verified adds leveraged into Cascade Expansion loops across sibling stations.
- **Week 12 (The Harvest & Revenue Conversion):** Thank-You Economy protocol deployed, physical station postcards mailed, tour dates executed, revenue logged in Airplay-to-Income Ledger.

IMPLEMENTATION DRILLS & PASS STANDARDS

- **Drill 1 — The Annual 3-Campaign Architecture (30 min).** Lay out the next 12 months in your calendar. Designate three distinct 12-week campaign windows. Populate the Annual Release Calendar below.
- **Drill 2 — The Backwards-Engineered Impact Date (20 min).** For your upcoming release, establish your formal Radio Impact Date (a Tuesday morning). Backwards-engineer exact calendar deadlines for Weeks 1 through 12.
- **Drill 3 — The Buffer & Code Freeze Lock (15 min).** Establish a mandatory 14-day ‘Code Freeze’ window between asset delivery and first outbound sends to ensure zero operational scrambling.
- **Drill 4 — The Capacity Audit (15 min).** Verify that your recording, production, and touring commitments align with your three planned campaign windows with zero scheduling conflicts.

ACTION WORKSHEET & OPERATIONAL PROTOCOL

Protocol Document: `12-WEEK QUARTERLY CAMPAIGN MASTER CALENDAR`

Complete the structured table below as part of your lesson implementation. This worksheet directly replaces legacy spreadsheets with a publication-grade execution protocol.

Campaign Week	Operational Phase	Core Mission Objectives	Deliverables Produced	Gatekeeper Milestone
Weeks 1-2 (T-8)	Proof & Asset Build	Finalize audio masters & metadata	Clean WAV, 90s Weapon, Proof Stack	Audio package verified 100%
Weeks 3-4 (T-6)	Target Architecture	Score stations & populate War Room	Format scorecards, 20 locked targets	Gatekeepers verified

Weeks 5-6 (T-4)	Weapon Staging	Update Command Deck EPK & drafts	One-Page URL live, 7 gates green	All Load Sequence gates passed
Weeks 7-8 (T-2)	Tour Pre-Roll Sync	Coordinate venue dates with radio	Tour Pre-Roll calendar locked	Interview windows proposed
Week 9 (T-0)	Launch & Wave 1	Dispatch Wave 1 (Top 10 targets)	First sends logged @ 9:30 AM	Wave 1 opens & replies tracked
Week 10 (T+1)	Wave 2 & Touch 2	Dispatch Wave 2 + Touch 2 value drop	30s hook cut delivered to Wave 1	Dialogue initiated across targets
Week 11 (T+2)	Touch 3 & Cascade	Final touch exit + expansion loops	Cascade pitches to sibling stations	First adds confirmed & logged
Week 12 (T+3)	Harvest & Loop	Deploy thank-yous, gigs, revenue	Postcards mailed, revenue logged	Allies transitioned to 30/10/10

WAR-ROOM NOTES

WAR-ROOM DIRECTIVE — 6.3 The Release Calendar That Dominates Quarters

THE DANGER OF THE DECEMBER RATINGS FREEZE

Never launch an independent radio campaign between December 1st and January 5th.

- During December, commercial and public radio stations enter the “Holiday Freeze.”
- Many stations switch to 24/7 holiday music or freeze all playlist changes to protect their fourth-quarter Arbitron ratings books.
- Programming staffs take extended holiday vacations, and music meetings are suspended.

OPTIMAL ANNUAL LAUNCH WINDOWS:

1. **Window A (Late Winter / Spring):** January 15 – April 15 (Fresh budgets, new music appetites, SXSW season).
2. **Window B (Early Summer):** May 1 – July 15 (Upbeat programming, summer festival and tour season).
3. **Window C (Fall / Back-to-Campus):** September 1 – November 10 (College radio returns, major fall tour runs).

FREQUENCY DOMINION COMMUNITY DRILLS

1. Post your 12-Month Annual Campaign Calendar displaying your three designated 12-week operational windows.
2. Share your backwards-engineered Radio Impact Date for your next single release.
3. Discuss how shifting from a monthly release mindset to a quarterly campaign model reduces operational anxiety.
4. Confirm that your planned release dates avoid the December Holiday Freeze.

Key Takeaways

REMEMBER THIS

- Twelve weeks, three releases.
- Timing is market-attention windows by quarter.
- Q4 is the closed window — use it for strategy.

Self-Assessment · Check Your Mastery

PASS BEFORE YOU MOVE ON

- 1. Is my 12-week, three-release calendar set?
- 2. Are releases aligned to the market-attention windows?
- 3. Is Q4 reserved for the audit and strategy season?